



BEFORE

In Judeo-Christian cultures, the Biblical story of the Creation was so fundamental to the way people viewed the world that challenges to it were almost unthinkable.



ADAM AND EVE

Creationism is the belief that the universe and everything in it was created by a god. Jewish and Christian creationists believe that the world was created exactly as stated in the Bible. Based on a **literal reading** of this, the Church believed that the **world was created between 6000 and 4000 BCE**, and that Earth and its species of plants and animals, including humans, are unchanging. The young Charles Darwin was influenced by theologians such as William Paley, who argued that the natural world was too complex not to have had a creator.

CHALLENGES TO CREATIONISM

In 1785 Scottish geologist James Hutton proposed that the Earth is being **continuously reshaped by steady change**, not by Biblical events such as the Creation and the Flood. This “steady state” view was later added to by British geologist Sir Charles Lyell, in his *Principles of Geology* (1830). Other challenges came from Darwin’s grandfather, Erasmus Darwin, who in 1794 noted a **progressional change** in animals. French naturalist Jean-Baptiste de Lamarck also proposed a **theory of progressive development** in his *Philosophie Zoologique*, published in 1809.

Scientific specimens

Darwin collected these specimens (two fish and an eel) during his five years on HMS *Beagle*, between 1831 and 1836.

